Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J 10 7 3 ♥ 9 8 6 4 ♦ K 7 ♣ A K	
♠ 5 2 ♥ Q J 10 ♦ J 9 8 2 ♣ 9 6 3 2		♠ 9 4 ♥ A 2 ♦ 10 6 4 3 ♣ Q J 10 7 5
	♠ K Q 8 6 ♥ K 7 5 3 ♦ A Q 5 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	2♥
Pass	4♥	Pass	4♠
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♣Q

You are East. The bidding has been as shown.

You lead the ♣Q, West plays low and North wins the ♣A.

North pulls trumps in 2 rounds. He then takes the ♦K, ♦Q, ♦A, discarding a ♥ on the last one. Next he plays dummy's last ♣ to his ♣K.

Having done all this, North now plays a low ♥ from his hand. What do you play?

Play the ♥A.

If you followed what North was doing you will realize that he has eliminated both the ♦s and ♣s from both his hand and dummy. If it isn't clear that he is now out of ♣s, just remember the bidding - he must have had 5 ♠s and 4 ♥s.

Suppose you play low on this ♥ (as North hopes you will). Dummy's ♥K will take the trick, and when another ♥ is played you will have to win it with your now bare ♥A. You will then have to play a ♦ or a ♣, giving North a ruff and sluff.

But if you take your ♥A now, then exit with your ♥2, North can win the ♥K but will still have to lose a ♥ to West.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 8 4 3
♥ Q 10 4
♦ 8 7 3
♣ J 8 7 4

♠ 10 7 2
♥ J 8 7 3 2
♦ A K Q
♣ A K

♠ A 6
♥ A K 9 6 5
♦ J 10 5
♣ Q 10 2

♠ K Q J 9 5
♥ —
♦ 9 6 4 2
♣ 9 6 5 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♥	Pass
3♦	Pass	3NT	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠K

You are North. The bidding has been as shown.

South led the ♠K, won by East's ♠A. East played a small ♣ to dummy's ♣A, then led dummy's ♥J.

What do you play? ♥Q or ♥4?

Play the ♥4.

Remember that East opened 1♥, so he has 5 of them. With only 3 trumps out he has no intention of finessing. Perhaps he led the ♥J just to tempt you to cover in this situation.

If you play low he will win with one of his high ♥s and then you will have a sure ♥ winner. Along with the ♠ winner South has you will defeat the slam.

If you cover the ♥J with your ♥Q East will again win with one of his high ones. But now the position will be clear to East and he will return to dummy and play another ♥, finessing your ♥10. With no trump loser he will make the slam.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 6
♥ 10 5 4
♦ A K 3
♣ A Q 7 4

♠ A 9 5 2
♥ 7 2
♦ 8 6 4
♣ 10 8 5 3

♠ K 10 7 4
♥ A 3
♦ J 10 9 2
♣ K J 9

♠ 8 3
♥ K Q J 9 8 6
♦ Q 7 5
♣ 6 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♥2

You are West. The bidding has been as shown.

You decide a trump lead is called for and lead the ♥2. Your partner wins with the ♥A and plays the ♦J. South lets this go to dummy's ♦K, (but you know he has ♦Q), then plays a trump back to his ♥K, pulling the 2 outstanding trumps from West and East.

South's next play is the ♠3 from his hand. Do you play your ♠A or not?

Play the ♠A.

Even if South doesn't have the ♠K he can establish a ♠ winner just by leading twice toward the ♠ Q J. That winner will take care of whatever black-suit loser he may have.

If East has a ♣ trick it is important to get it established soon. So go up with the ♠A and play a ♣ through dummy's ♣ A Q. When South tries the ♠ suit again **EAST** can win and cash his ♣K for the setting trick.

If you play low on South's ♠ play East will be forced to win the trick and he cannot profitably attack the ♣ suit from his side.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 9 4 2 ♥ 7 3 ♦ 10 7 5 ♣ Q 10 6 5	
♠ K Q 5 ♥ A Q 8 5 2 ♦ A 9 2 ♣ K J	N W E S	♠ 6 ♥ K J 9 6 ♦ Q 6 3 ♣ A 7 4 3 2
	♠ A 10 8 7 3 ♥ 10 4 ♦ K J 8 4 ♣ 9 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♥ by West
Lead: ♥3

You are South. The bidding has been as shown.

Partner led the ♥3, you play ♥10 and West wins the ♥A. West pulls the last two trumps by leading low to dummy's ♥Q. He now calls for the ♠6. Will you play your ♠A or not?

Play the ♠3.

When a singleton in dummy is led through your Ace it is more often better to play low than to go up with the Ace. Declarer might not even have the King, or he may have the King Jack combination and guess wrong.

Here it works out best to play low even though West has the ♠ K Q 5.

Assume you play your ♠A. West will play his loser, of course, and later will be able to discard two of dummy's ♦s on the ♠ K Q. He can then ruff his two ♦ losers and make the contract.

Now assume you play low. West will play the ♠Q which will win the trick and he will no longer have a ♠ loser.**BUT** - now he will have no way to dispose of the two ♦ losers and will go down 1.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A J 9 6 5 ♥ A 9 6 2 ♦ K 7 ♣ Q 3	
♠ 7 2 ♥ Q 10 3 ♦ Q 8 6 2 ♣ J 10 5 4		♠ 8 4 ♥ K 5 ♦ J 10 9 5 4 ♣ 9 8 6 2
	♠ K Q 10 3 ♥ J 8 7 4 ♦ A 3 ♣ A K 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	3♠	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♦J

You are East. The bidding has been as shown.

You lead the ♦J and dummy's ♦A wins the first trick. Declarer pulls trumps with dummy's ♠K, then his ♠A. He then plays his ♦K and follows with ♣Q, ♣K and ♣A, discarding a ♥ from his hand on the last.

With all that completed North plays the ♥A. What do you play?

Play the ♥K.

It may look foolish to waste your ♥K but look what will happen if you don't. North will follow up with another ♥ and when you win the ♥K you will be forced to play a minor suit. Since both South and North are out of ♦s and ♣s you will be giving them a ruff-sluff and the contract.

But if you dump your ♥K under North's ♥A look at what's left. North has ♥ losers and when he plays a ♥ from either hand West will scoop up two tricks with his ♥ Q 10.